Twenty Famous Chess Positions

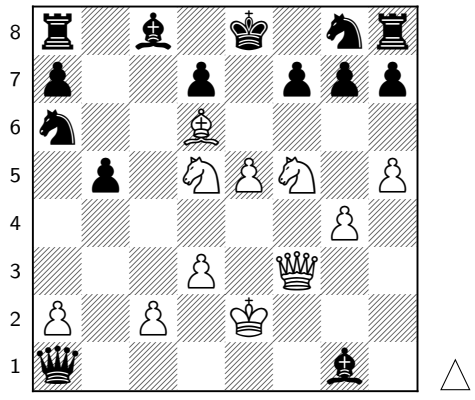
White or Black to play and force checkmate in three moves

How to use this document. Each diagram shows the position with the side to move indicated by the marker beside the board and by the caption. In every position the side to move has a forced checkmate in *exactly* three of its own moves—no faster mate exists, and there is a single winning first move. Try each one before looking at the solutions at the end.

About the positions. Positions 1–5 come from famous games (the Immortal Game, the Evergreen Game, the "Game of the Century", Réti's mate) and from Sam Loyd's celebrated 1859 "Charles XII" problem. Positions 6–20 illustrate classic mating patterns and combinations: back-rank mates, Anastasia's and the Arabian mate, the smothered mate, double check, promotion and under-promotion. These last fifteen are illustrative positions built around those themes rather than transcriptions of specific historic games. Every position was verified by computer (an exhaustive mate-in-three search) to be exactly as described.

1. The Immortal Game

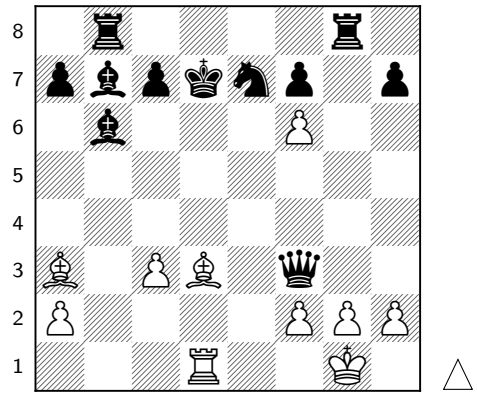
Anderssen – Kieseritzky, London 1851. Position after 20...Na6.



White to play and mate in three

2. The Evergreen Game

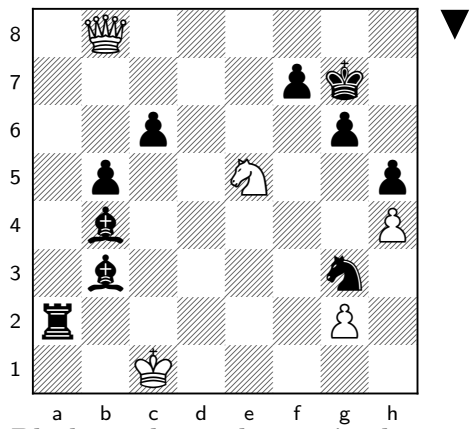
Anderssen – Dufresne, Berlin 1852. Position after 21...Kxd7.



White to play and mate in three

3. The Game of the Century

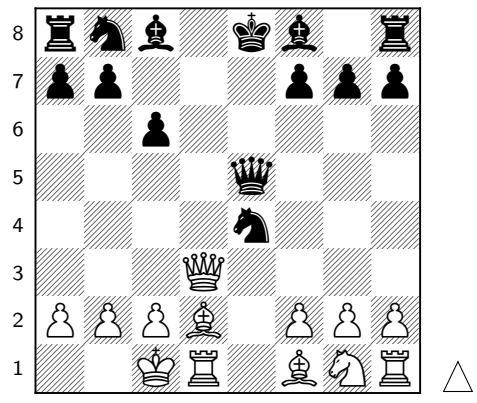
D. Byrne – R. J. Fischer, New York 1956. Position after 39.Kc1.



Black to play and mate in three

4. Réti's Mate

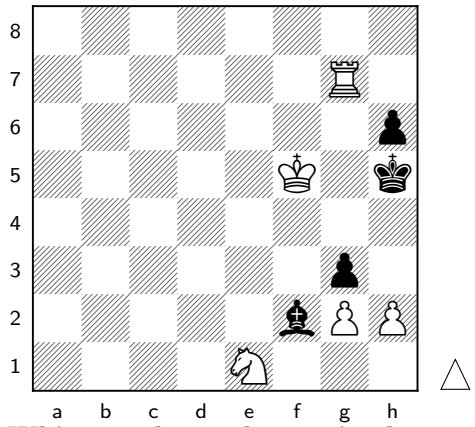
Réti – Tartakower, Vienna 1910. Position after 8...Nxe4.



White to play and mate in three

5. Loyd's Charles XII Problem

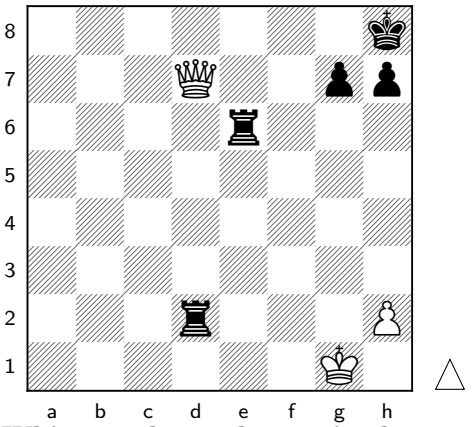
Sam Loyd, 1859.



White to play and mate in three

6. Back-Rank Mate: Queen Sacrifices

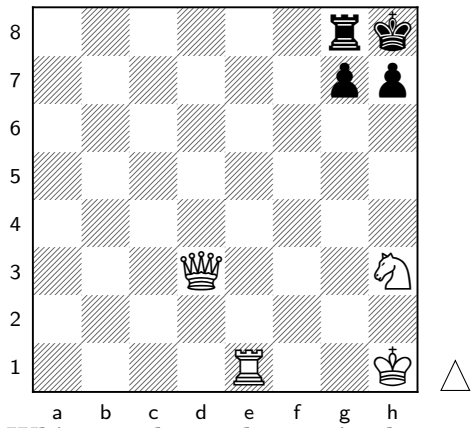
Classic back-rank pattern.



White to play and mate in three

7. Back-Rank Mate: Quiet Knight Move

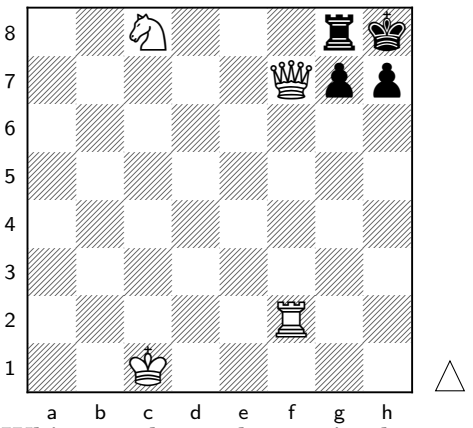
Classic back-rank pattern.



White to play and mate in three

8. Queen Sacrifice and Knight Support

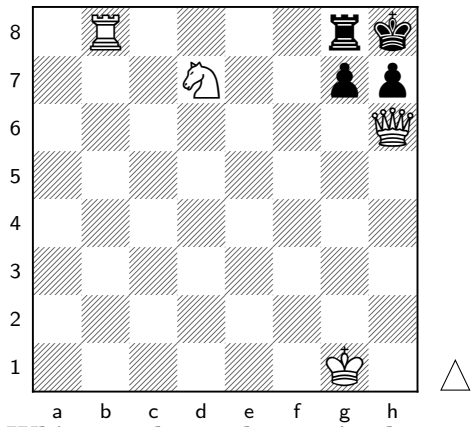
Classic combination.



White to play and mate in three

9. Rook Sacrifice: Queen on the Long Diagonal

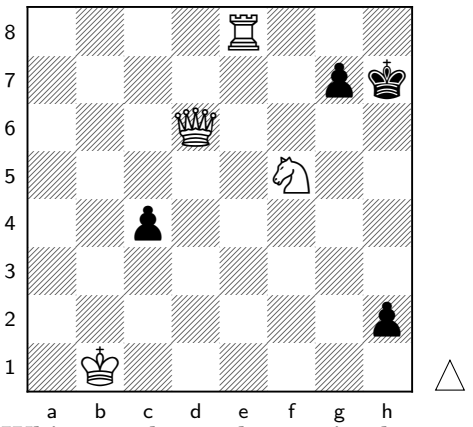
Classic combination.



White to play and mate in three

10. Rook Sacrifice: Queen and Knight Mate

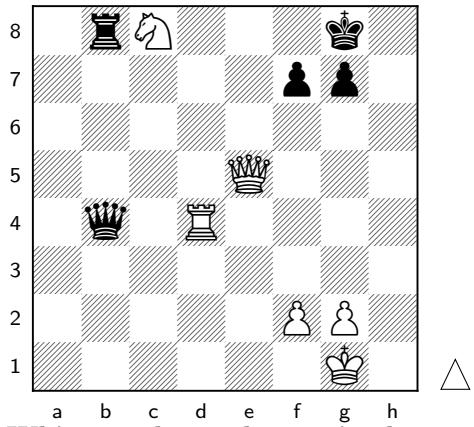
Classic combination.



White to play and mate in three

11. Anastasia's Mate

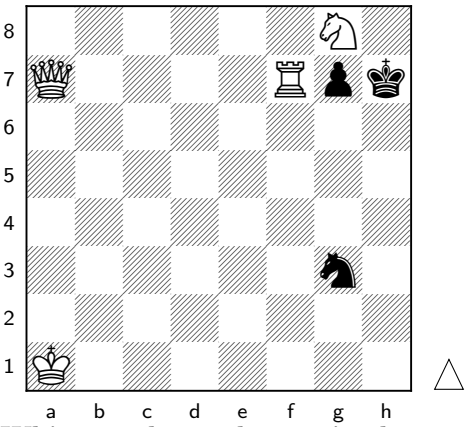
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

12. Arabian Mate

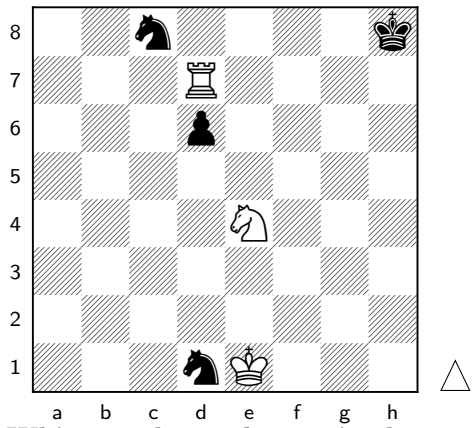
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

13. Arabian Mate: Rook Lift

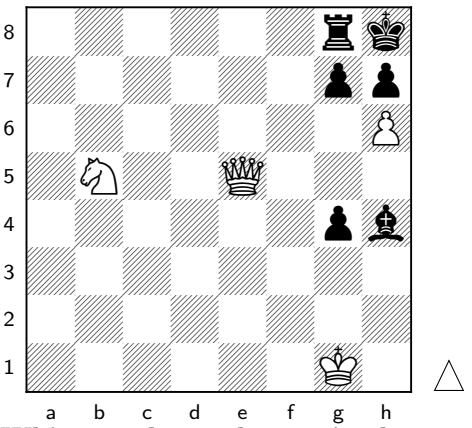
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

14. Smothered Mate

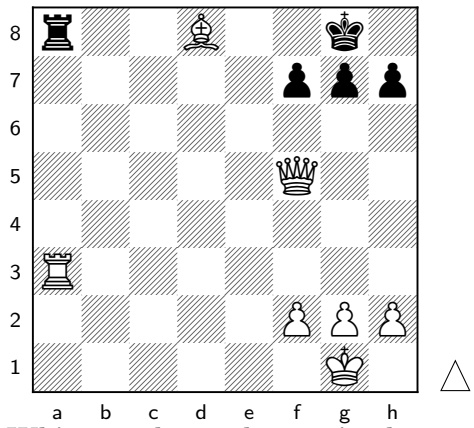
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

15. Double-Check Mate

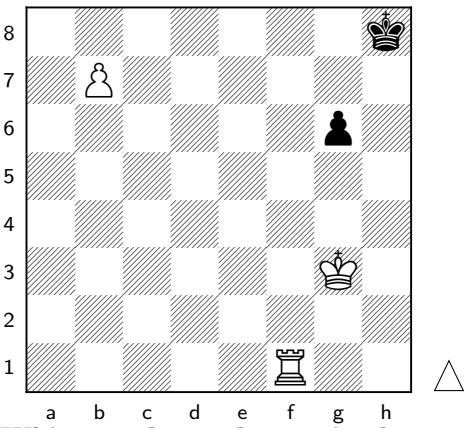
Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

16. Promotion Mate

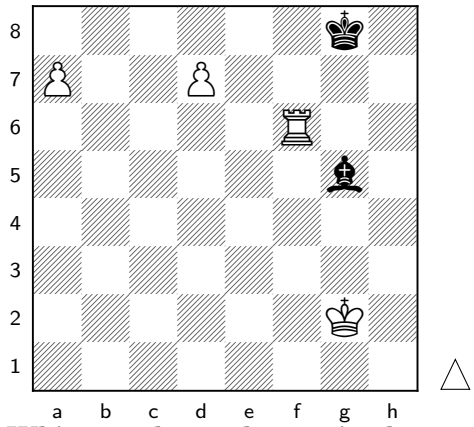
Study-style promotion.



White to play and mate in three

17. Double Promotion

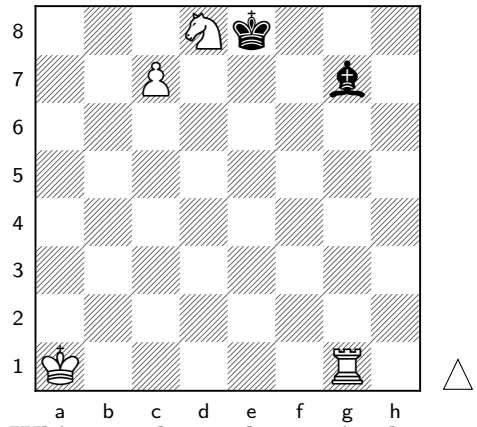
Study-style promotion.



White to play and mate in three

18. Under-Promotion to a Rook

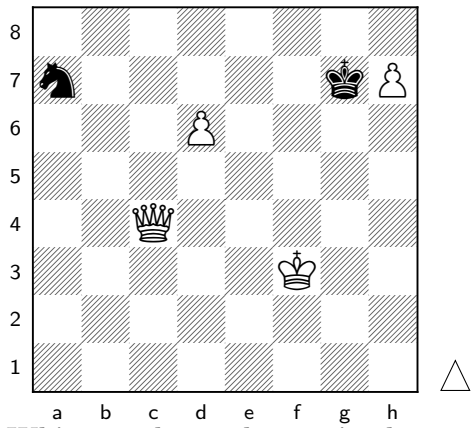
Study-style under-promotion.



White to play and mate in three

19. Under-Promotion to a Bishop

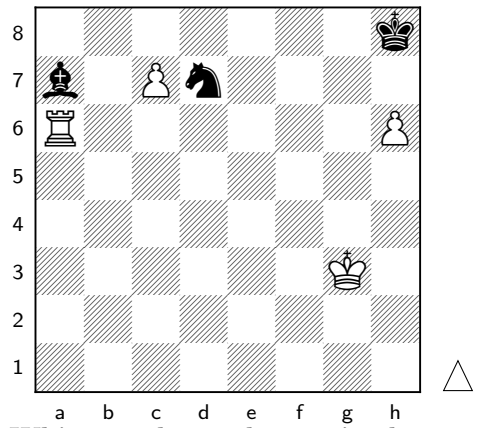
Study-style under-promotion.



White to play and mate in three

20. Promotion, Sacrifice and Queen-and-Pawn Mate

Classic mating pattern.



White to play and mate in three

Solutions

Each solution shows the main line: the key first move, Black's (or White's) best defence, and the mating finish. In every case the defender has no way to avoid mate on the third move.

1. **The Immortal Game.** `1.Nxg7+ Kd8 2.Qf6+ Nxf6 3.Be7#`
   Anderssen has already given up both rooks and a bishop; now the queen goes too, and three minor pieces deliver mate.

2. **The Evergreen Game.** `1.Bf5+ Ke8 2.Bd7+ Kf8 3.Bxe7#`
   After the rook and queen sacrifices, the two bishops finish the job.

3. **The Game of the Century.** `1...Ne2+ 2.Kb1 Nc3+ 3.Kc1 Rc2#`
   Thirteen-year-old Fischer's minor pieces and rook hunt the white king. (The game's own finish is 41...Rc2#.)

4. **Réti's Mate.** `1.Qd8+ Kxd8 2.Bg5+ Kc7 3.Bd8#`
   A queen sacrifice opens the d-file; the bishop then gives double check with the rook and mates on d8. (If 2...Ke8, then 3.Rd8#.)

5. **Loyd's Charles XII Problem.** `1.Rxg3 Bxg3 2.Nf3 Bxh2 3.g4#`
   The first part of Loyd's famous three-part story problem set at the Battle of Bender: a rook sacrifice and a quiet knight move set up the pawn mate.

6. **Back-Rank Mate: Queen Sacrifices.** `1.Qc8+ Rd8 2.Qxd8+ Re8 3.Qxe8#`
   Two queen offers drag Black's rooks away from the defence of the back rank.

7. **Back-Rank Mate: Quiet Knight Move.** `1.Ng5 g6 2.Qd4+ Rg7 3.Re8#`
   The quiet 1.Ng5 threatens Qh7 and forces the weakening ...g6 before the queen check and rook mate.

8. **Queen Sacrifice and Knight Support.** `1.Qxg8+ Kxg8 2.Ne7+ Kh8 3.Rf8#`
   The queen deflects the rook, then a knight check and rook mate on the back rank follow.

9. **Rook Sacrifice: Queen on the Long Diagonal.** `1.Rxg8+ Kxg8 2.Qe6+ Kh8 3.Qe8#`
   A rook sacrifice on g8 forces the king onto the back rank, and the queen mates there.

10. **Rook Sacrifice: Queen and Knight Mate.** `1.Rh8+ Kxh8 2.Qf8+ Kh7 3.Qxg7#`
    Black's far-advanced h-pawn and c-pawn are too slow; the rook sacrifice and queen check win first.

11. **Anastasia's Mate.** `1.Rd8+ Qf8 2.Ne7+ Kh7 3.Qh2#`
    The knight on e7 covers g6 and g8 while Black's own pawn on g7 blocks the king in; the queen mates along the h-file.

12. **Arabian Mate.** `1.Rxg7+ Kh8 2.Nf6 Nh5 3.Rh7#`
    Rook and knight cooperate in the corner: the rook mates on h7 with the knight on f6 guarding it and covering g8.

13. **Arabian Mate: Rook Lift.** `1.Nf6 Ne7 2.Rxe7 Ne3 3.Rh7#`
    The same Arabian pattern, reached after the rook eliminates the defending knight on e7.

14. **Smothered Mate.** `1.Nd6 Bf2+ 2.Kg2 Be1 3.Nf7#`
    The black king is hemmed in by its own rook and pawns, so the knight on f7 delivers mate.

15. **Double-Check Mate.** `1.Rxa8 f6 2.Qe6+ Kf8 3.Be7#`
    After the rook eliminates the a8 rook, Qe6+ drives the king to f8 and the bishop mates on e7.

16. **Promotion Mate.** `1.Rf7 Kg8 2.Rd7 g5 3.b8=Q#`
    The rook cuts the king off along the seventh rank so the b-pawn can promote with mate.

17. **Double Promotion.** `1.d8=Q+ Kh7 2.Qc7+ Kg8 3.a8=Q#`
    Two passed pawns each promote to a queen, the second one giving mate.

18. **Under-Promotion to a Rook.** `1.Rxg7 Kf8 2.Ne6+ Ke8 3.c8=R#`
    Promoting to a queen would stalemate Black, so the pawn promotes to a rook and mates.

19. **Under-Promotion to a Bishop.** `1.Qg8+ Kf6 2.h8=B+ Kf5 3.Qg4#`
    Promoting to a bishop gives check along the long diagonal and opens the way for the queen to mate.

20. **Promotion, Sacrifice and Queen-and-Pawn Mate.** `1.c8=Q+ Nf8 2.Qxf8+ Kh7 3.Qg7#`
    The new queen captures the knight on f8 with check, driving the king to h7, and then mates on g7 supported by the h6-pawn.